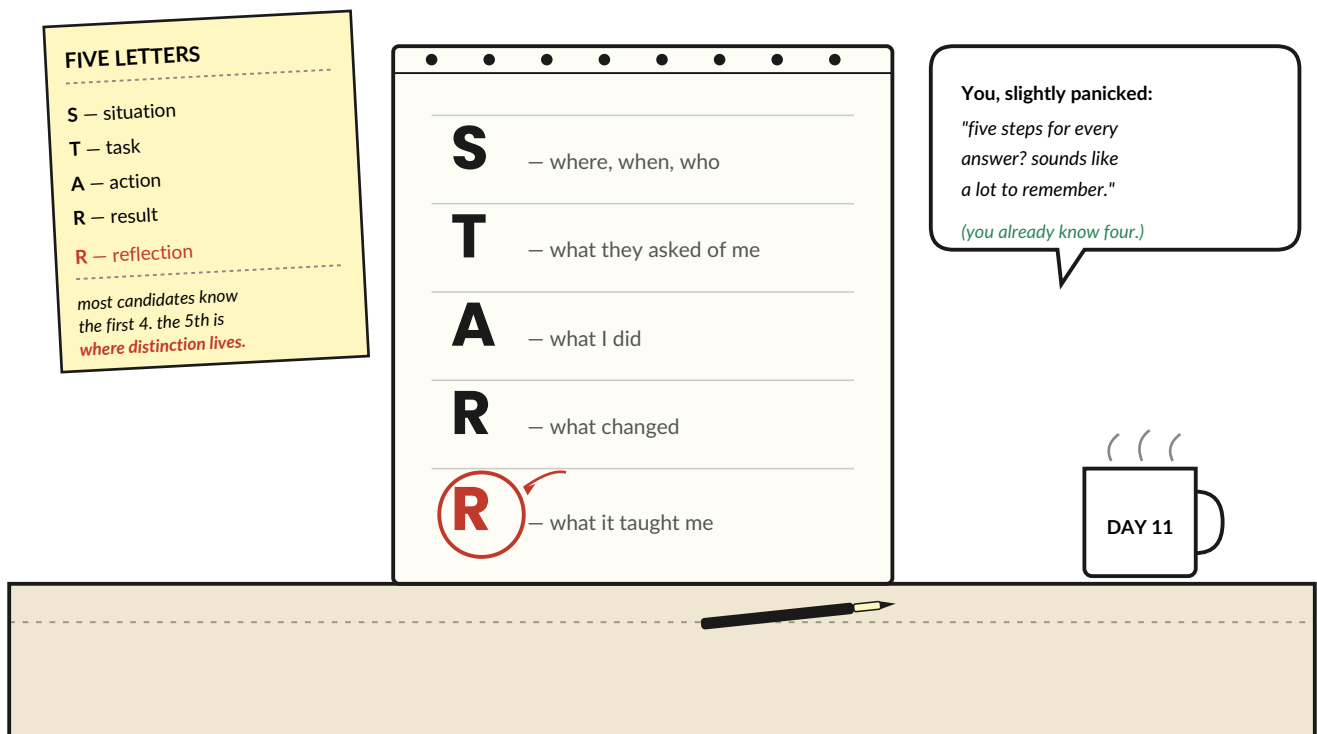


11

the only new technique you need

STARR

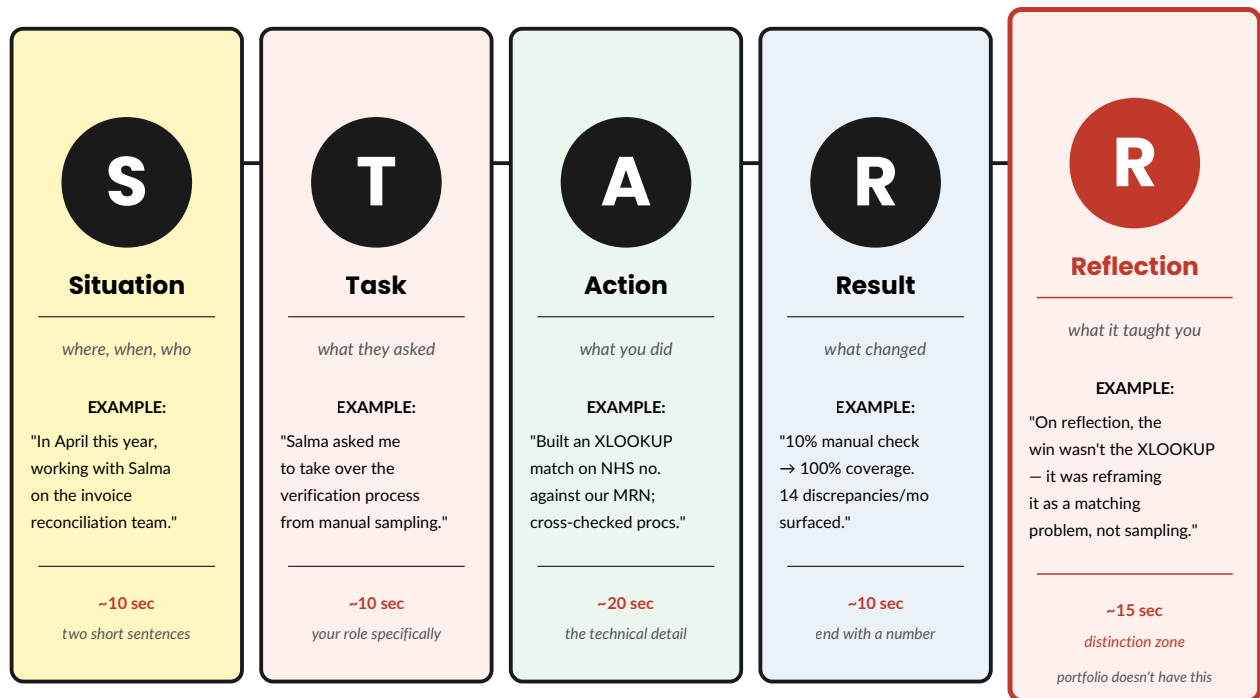
5 letters · 1 answer shape · every spoken response in the discussion



One shape. Every spoken answer. If you've prepared for a competency-based interview before, you already know **STAR** – the first four letters. AM2 needs a fifth: **Reflection**. That second R is the new thing today – and it's where Distinction marks live.

Five layers, one answer

Every spoken answer follows the same shape. Five layers, each one second-or-third nature once you've used it a few times. The fifth is the AM2-specific one — it's what makes the difference between Pass and Distinction.



First four layers (STAR) — familiar territory if you've prepped for interviews. The fifth R is the AM2-specific one.

What each letter asks for

If you've used STAR before, layers 1–4 are familiar. The fifth R is the bit AM2 specifically wants.

Layer	Answers the question	A good one sounds like
S — Situation	Where? When? Who was involved?	<i>"In April, working with the booking team..."</i>
T — Task	What was asked of you?	<i>"My manager asked me to take over invoice verification..."</i>
A — Action	What did you actually do?	<i>"I built an XLOOKUP match between the two ID fields..."</i>
R — Result	What changed because of it?	<i>"Coverage moved from 10% to 100%, surfacing 14 issues/month..."</i>
R — Reflection	What did it teach you? What would you do differently?	<i>"On reflection, the real win was reframing it as a matching problem, not a sampling one..."</i>

SHOW THIS OFF

You don't have to say the words "Situation, Task, Action..." out loud. The assessor isn't checking off letters. They're hearing whether *all five layers are in the answer*. Layer by layer, in roughly that order — even if you never name the framework.

Why the second R is everything

One simple fact: **the portfolio doesn't contain reflection**. By design. The assessment plan explicitly excludes self-reflection from the written evidence. So the discussion — specifically the second R in STARR — is the *only* place reflection shows up. Which means it's where Distinction marks live.

Pass-level Result

"Coverage went from 10% to 100% and we caught 14 issues a month."

Describes the outcome — correct, complete, but it's still just describing.

Distinction-level Reflection

"On reflection, the real win wasn't the XLOOKUP — it was reframing the work as a matching problem rather than a sampling one. I'd take that mindset into any verification task."

Evaluates the work, generalises the insight, anticipates future application.



BRAIN POWER

Three reflection prompts that almost always work: *"the real win wasn't X — it was Y"* · *"I'd take this approach into Z next time"* · *"what I'd do differently with hindsight is..."* Pick one, fit your story to it, practise it three times. That's the Distinction move.

A full STARR in 60 seconds

Below: a complete answer to a typical opening question, laid out layer by layer.
Read it aloud once. Then read it again at the suggested pace.

A FULL STARR ANSWER — 60-second transcript

Q: "Tell me about a piece of data work where the analysis shaped a business decision."

S

SITUATION — where, when, who

"In April this year, I was working with our External Provider Reconciliation team — Salma is the lead. We were processing about 1,400 invoices a month from imaging providers."

T

TASK — what was asked of you

"Salma asked me to take over the verification process. The previous method was a manual check of about 10% of invoices, which was leaving discrepancies undetected."

A

ACTION — what you did

"I designed an automated reconciliation using XLOOKUP to match the external provider's NHS numbers against our internal MRNs. I added columns to pull procedure name from UCLH data so we could cross-check what was billed against what was actually clinically done."

R

RESULT — what changed

"We went from checking 10% to 100% coverage. We caught about 14 discrepancies a month — most were legitimate variations, but a few were billing errors we corrected with providers."

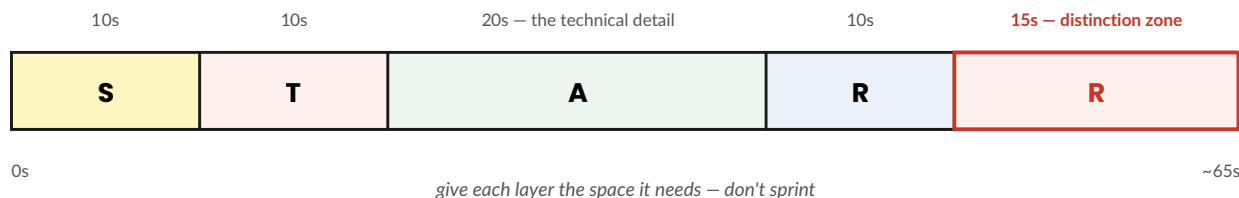
R

REFLECTION — what it taught you / what you'd do differently

"On reflection, the win wasn't really the XLOOKUP technique — it was reframing the work as a matching problem rather than a sampling one. I'd take that mindset into any future verification task: where the data has a unique key, you can audit the whole population."

How long each layer should be

STARR is 60–75 seconds end-to-end for a typical question. Most learners overspend on Situation and underspend on Reflection. The pacing below is the corrective.



The two most common pacing errors

1. Over-spending on Situation. Half your answer is context-setting and the assessor's eyes glaze over. Aim for two short sentences max.

2. Under-spending on the second R. You land the Result and stop. The Reflection layer gets clipped to one sentence, or vanishes. Give it the same space as the Result. Distinction lives there.

SHOW THIS OFF

If the assessor is taking notes by the time you reach the second R, you've earned the time. Don't rush the reflection because you sense the silence — the silence is them *writing*.

Where STARR answers go wrong

Four recurring patterns. Each loses marks for a different reason. The first one is the most common.

1. The Context Dump

Three minutes of background before getting to what you did. The assessor wanted a 60-second answer and got a lecture. *Fix:* two short sentences for Situation, then move on. The story isn't the context; the context lets the story start.

2. The Skipped Task

You jump straight from Situation to Action without naming what was asked of you specifically. The assessor doesn't know whether you led the work, supported it, or were handed it. *Fix:* one sentence on Task — "My manager asked me to..." or "I volunteered to take this on because..."

3. The Hidden Result

You describe what you did but never name what changed. The Action goes on for 30 seconds and lands without a number, a date, or a decision. *Fix:* always end the Result with a measurable — "from 10% to 100% coverage", "reporting cut from 4 hours to 20 minutes", "the dashboard went into the exec meeting and was approved".



RED FLAG · THE MISSING REFLECTION

You land the Result and stop. The fifth layer doesn't happen. This is the single most common reason apprentices hit Pass on every KSB but fall short of the Distinction descriptors (D1, D2, D3). The assessor can see in the portfolio that you did the work — what they need to hear in the discussion is *what you took from it*.

The fix: after every Result, pause for a beat, then start with "on reflection..." or "what that taught me...". Even one strong sentence is enough.



SHARPEN YOUR PENCIL 40 minutes — one STARR template per anchor

Take each anchor story from Day 10. Bullet a few words per layer — not sentences. The full sentence comes when you say it out loud.

Anchor 1 *name your story:*

S*where, when, who***T***what they asked***A***what you did***R***what changed***R***on reflection...*

Anchor 2 *name your story:*

S*where, when, who***T***what they asked***A***what you did***R***what changed***R***on reflection...*

Anchor 3 *name your story:*

S *where, when, who*

T *what they asked*

A *what you did*

R *what changed*

R *on reflection...*

Anchor 4 *name your story:*

S *where, when, who*

T *what they asked*

A *what you did*

R *what changed*

R *on reflection...*

Halfway House

Five quick questions. Answer in your head first; check below.

1. STARR is an acronym I should say out loud during the discussion.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

2. The first four layers (STAR) are the same shape used in competency-based interviews generally.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

3. Most learners over-spend on Situation and under-spend on Reflection.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

4. The Result and the Reflection are the same thing – both describe what happened.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

5. If I forget the Reflection in one answer, I can add it later when the assessor asks me about the same KSB again.

☐ **True** ☐ **False**

Answers

1. **False.** Don't name the framework. The assessor wants to hear all five layers in your answer, not the acronym.
2. **True.** If you've prepared for any structured interview, layers 1–4 are familiar – the fifth R is the AM2-specific add.
3. **True.** The two pacing errors that cost marks. The R-bar in the pacing diagram is the corrective.
4. **False.** Result *describes* what changed; Reflection *evaluates* what it taught you. Different verbs – different layers.
5. **True – and recommended.** The assessor often revisits a topic. Use the second visit to add what you forgot. "*Going back to the dashboard piece for a moment – on reflection...*"

There are no *Dumb* Questions

- Q:** *I've never heard of STAR or STARR. Is this a real framework or something you've made up?*
- A:** STAR is a widely-used competency-interview framework — you'll find it in any recruitment or coaching book. STARR with the second R (Reflection) is a common adaptation for reflective discussions like AM2. The names matter less than the shape; the shape is what scores.
- Q:** *What if my story doesn't fit STARR neatly? E.g., the work is ongoing, no clear "result" yet.*
- A:** Use what's there. Even a project mid-flight has an interim Result — *"so far, we've onboarded the first 12 sites and reduced report-turnaround from 5 days to 2"* — and an interim Reflection — *"what's been useful so far is the early stakeholder mapping; if I were starting again I'd build that in even sooner"*. Don't pretend the work is done; describe where it is.
- Q:** *I'm scared I'll forget the order under pressure.*
- A:** Two helpers. **First:** the order matches how a story naturally unfolds — when, what was needed, what I did, what happened, what I learned. You're not memorising an alphabet, you're telling a story. **Second:** on the day, write S T A R R down the side of your notepad before the call starts. Glance at it between answers. It's allowed.
- Q:** *My anchor stories were team-based. How do I describe what I did?*
- A:** Be specific about your contribution. *"The team migrated the dashboards; my piece was the data quality validation layer."* Team context is fine in Situation; Action should be about you specifically. The assessor needs to grade your work, not the team's.
- Q:** *What if the Reflection is something I'm not proud of — e.g., "I'd have asked for help sooner"?*
- A:** That's exactly the kind of Reflection that scores at Distinction. The descriptors reward critical evaluation of your own work, not self-promotion. *"What I'd do differently is..."* is a stronger move than *"What I did brilliantly was..."*. Be honest.
- Q:** *Can I use the same anchor story for different questions?*
- A:** Yes — and you should. A strong anchor story covers multiple KSBs, so it'll be relevant to several discussion questions. The Situation, Task, and Action stay the same; the Result and Reflection layers can shift depending on which angle the question asks about.

*Five layers, in order.
Skip none. Especially not the last.*

Say it for real

Three opening-style questions. Answer each with a full STARR, out loud. Use your anchor stories from Day 10. The first time will feel mechanical; by the third, it flows.

Q1 — Tell me about a piece of data work you're proud of.

The shape: pick your strongest anchor — the one that most easily yields a result and a reflection. Use the worked example on page 5 as the cadence model.

Q2 — Describe a time you found a data quality issue and what you did about it.

The shape: a different anchor — one from your Data Analysis & Validation content area. The Action layer is where the technique lives (Group By, Three Questions Before You Delete, Two-Route Check). The Reflection should generalise: *"what that taught me about how to spot quality issues earlier..."*

Q3 — Tell me about a stakeholder conversation that didn't go as planned.

The shape: a softer-KSB anchor — one from Approach to Work. Be specific in Situation; honest in Reflection. *"What I'd do differently is..."* is a stronger ending than *"I handled it well by..."*.

SHOW THIS OFF

After each practice answer, time it. If you finished in under 45 seconds, you under-answered. If you went over 90, you over-answered. Aim for the 60–75 second band. The pacing chart on page 6 is your guide.

Bullet Points — the chapter in 30 seconds

- STARR is the only new technique you need for AM2. Five layers, one shape, used every answer.
- Situation • Task • Action • Result • Reflection. In that order, but you never say the words out loud.
- The first four (STAR) are familiar. If you've done any structured interview prep, you've used them.
- The second R is the AM2-specific add. Reflection. Where Distinction lives.
- Pacing: roughly 60–75 seconds. S 10s • T 10s • A 20s • R 10s • R 15s.
- Four common mistakes. The Context Dump, the Skipped Task, the Hidden Result, the Missing Reflection.
- "On reflection..." is the phrase that unlocks the last layer. Use it deliberately.

TEST DRIVE

Tick each only when it's true:

- ☐ You can recite the five layers — S, T, A, R, R — from memory.
- ☐ You've drafted at least one full STARR for each of your four anchor stories.
- ☐ You've said the worked example (page 5) aloud at least once.
- ☐ You can finish the sentence "on reflection..." for each anchor story.
- ☐ You've timed one answer and it landed in the 60–75 second band.

COMING UP — DAY 12

Data Gathering — STARR-ed. Tomorrow we take the first content area — *Data Gathering* — and work through three or four worked STARR answers using the K1, K4, K6 KSBs. Named device: **The "Why This Data?" Stack** — three layers (what data • why this data • what it cost the business to get wrong) that lifts a gathering answer toward Distinction D1.

that's Day 11 done — you've got the only technique you need.